Paragraph editing

Worksheet 2, Scientific Communication

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Edit the paragraph below, or a paragraph of your own. Use only the facts given. Do not invent numbers. This is fictional teaching data.

> In light of the fact that excessive heat in classrooms constitutes a significant problem for learning, the implementation of a reflective roof coating was undertaken in a number of classrooms. It was found that temperatures were much lower in the coated rooms, showing that the coating cools classrooms and will improve exam results. However, the difference was not statistically significant ($p>0.05$), so it can be concluded that the coating does not work.

Facts you may use: 12 coated and 12 standard classrooms. Mean afternoon temperature 29.4 °C and 30.6 °C. Difference 1.2 °C cooler in coated rooms (95% CI 2.5 °C cooler to 0.1 °C warmer). Head teachers volunteered the coated rooms. Exam results were not measured.

Step 1. Underline at least five problems. Look for wordy phrases, vague claims, missing denominators, causal language, and anything stated but not measured.

Step 2. Rewrite it. Aim for one point, then evidence, then interpretation.

Step 3. Swap with your partner. Check the rewrite for three things: is the size given, is the uncertainty given, and is any claim stronger than the data?